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Contemporary Artivism in Morocco: Transformations of Creative Dissent in Post-2011 and the New “Organic Artist”

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ABSTRACT

As the 2011 protests unfolded, artivism emerged in academic discussions on the SWANA region to describe artistic practices aimed at fostering social and political transformation. The area’s vibrant cultural landscape, along with the growing use of creative practices as forms of protest, drew increasing attention from both media and scholars, sparking a wave of studies on the phenomenon. Yet, much of this research has focused on artivism during the uprisings or in their immediate aftermath, often neglecting its subsequent development. This study seeks to fill such a gap, adopting a qualitative approach to trace the evolution of artivism in Morocco from 2011 to the present. Through a diachronic analysis of activist groups that emerged during the protests and remain active today, a new, de-romanticized understanding of the figure of the activist takes shape. No longer framed solely as an independent and oppositional actor, the activist is revealed to navigate a more nuanced and ambivalent relationship with the State. Driven to re-engage with the country’s cultural and political institutions in order to be visible and to survive economically, activists negotiate new spaces and forge alternative ways to remain dissident. Within this dynamic of dialogue and compromise, the activist increasingly takes on the outlines of what may be called an organic artist.

KEYWORDS

Artivism / Morocco / Dissent / Political Participation / Organic Artist

1 - Introduction

The nexus between art and politics, and the role of artistic production as a vehicle for sociopolitical change, have long been a subject of academic inquiry and philosophical reflection (Benjamin 1970; Rancière 2004; Reed 2005). Art is, at its core, a fundamentally social phenomenon (Bowman & Elliott & Silverman 2016): it is created by people, for people, embedded in every-day struggles – both small and large-scale – which inevitably surface in their cultural production (Milbrandt 2010). Yet, artivism extends beyond art’s conventional capacity of observing, absorbing and creatively reshaping reality. As Groys (2014:1) argues:

«Art activists do not want to merely criticize the art system or the general political and social conditions under which this system functions. Rather, they want to change these conditions by means of art – not so much inside the art system but outside it, in reality itself».

It is this explicit commitment to socio-political transformation that distinguishes activism from adjacent practices and concepts (Lippard 1984:349). This transformative orientation has been particularly visible in Morocco, where youth activism has turned to creative repertoires of action in response to the dynamics of the 2011 mobilizations. Unlike other regional movements, Moroccan protests did not lead to, nor explicitly call for, the overthrow of the monarchy (Benchemsi 2012; Boubia 2019). Initially, King Mohammed VI appeared responsive: in his speech of March 9, 2011, he promised a «comprehensive constitutional change» (Benchemsi 2012:59), including the rule of law, an independent judiciary, and an elected government. Yet, much like earlier reforms introduced during his reign,¹ this initiative proved to be a preventive measure, designed to defuse the momentum of the protests rather than enable genuine transformation. This approach reflects a long-standing strategy of top-down reforms,² in which the King retained firm control over the scope and direction of change (Cavatorta & Dalmaso 2013). The apparent “renegotiation” of authority thus revealed itself less as a sincere dialogue between state and society than as a strategy of cooptation, aimed at maintaining the regime’s legitimacy while neutralizing dissent (Maddy-Weitzman & Zisenwine 2013).

¹ From the beginning of his reign (1999), King Mohammed VI adopted a series of symbolic gestures and institutional reforms aimed at distancing himself from the authoritarian legacy of his father, Hassan II, and projecting the image of a modern and liberal monarch. A key moment was the creation of the Equity and Reconciliation Commission (IER) in 2004, tasked with investigating enforced disappearances, arbitrary detention, and torture from independence to 1999. Other initiatives included the establishment of the Royal Institute of Amazigh Culture (IRCAM) in 2002, the overhaul of the Family Code (*Moudawana*) in 2004, currently under review, and the launch of the National Initiative for Human Development (INDH) in 2005. Through such measures, King Mohammed VI has been able to cultivate an image of Morocco as a democratizing state, to the point that commentators have spoken of a “Moroccan exception” within the SWANA region, while remaining in total control of political power. To describe this shrewd combination of concessions and control, Almeida (2017:25) refers to it as a set of «cosmetic strategies». On this concept, see also Storm 2007.

² Since the early 90s, King Hassan II initiated a cautious process of political opening, partly in response to the post-Cold War international climate that strongly favored democratization and partly to provide a peaceful transition of power to his son. While these measures included limited improvements in human rights, a modest increase in parliamentary authority, greater political pluralism, and some attempts to curb corruption, they remained restricted in scope and left the autocratic foundations of political power largely untouched. For a deeper analysis see Ottaway & Riley 2006.

Faced with this adaptive authoritarian stance, many activists began to question the effectiveness of protest tactics employed during the demonstrations (ElHachimi 2016): tactics that, despite their visibility, had failed to produce substantial political change. In response, they turned to alternative forms of engagement, including those grounded in creativity and artistic expression (ElHachimi 2016; Borrillo 2019). Within this context, the term “activism” gained analytical traction.

A wide body of literature has since foregrounded the political significance of cultural production in Morocco (LeVine 2008, 2015; Jay 2013; Boubia 2015, 2019; Almeida 2017; Ahmadou & Bergh 2018; Bahmad 2019; Borrillo 2019; Abdelhak 2021), highlighting how artistic practices function as both critique and counter-narrative, particularly during a phase of political disillusionment and collective demobilization, as they contest dominant discourses and contribute to the reconfiguration of the public sphere – i.e. a physical and discursive space where confrontation unfolds, dissent is voiced, and possibilities for change are articulated³ (Fraser 1990, Mouffe 2002). Nevertheless, much of this research remains tied to the moment of the uprisings, often neglecting the subsequent evolution of activism. Over the past decade, Moroccan activism has undergone significant transformations. Specifically, it now includes younger generations who did not experience the 2011 protests firsthand; it engages with issues such as gender identity, queer liberation, decoloniality, and intersectionality; it embraces digital platforms as tools for expression and outreach; and, most notably, it follows a path of increasing institutionalization.

This study positions itself within and beyond such academic fields. While building upon foundational work that framed activism as a mode of resistance during the protest years, it aims to trace the longer historical arc of the phenomenon and capture its ongoing transformations, focusing on the period from the 2011 uprisings, when new activist collectives and associations emerged, up to December 2023, when the fieldwork of the research was completed. Specifically, it investigates how contemporary activism differs from earlier manifestations, how it intersects with Morocco’s broader processes of political and social change, and what role it plays in renegotiating the boundaries between dissent and co-optation. To this end, the article asks the following questions: Who are the key actors shaping today’s activist scene in Morocco? What are the discourses and themes that animate their work? How do activists navigate the institutional frameworks that both enable and constrain their practice? And how, and to what extent, do they articulate dissent?

What emerges is a portrait of the activist as more complex and nuanced than the autonomous, resistant figure commonly depicted in narratives shaped during the 2011 uprisings or in their immediate aftermath. Drawing on Gramsci’s (1971) notion of the

³ A more detailed discussion of the notion of “public sphere” is provided in section 2.

“organic intellectual” and its reinterpretation by Boubia (2019:96), this article proposes the concept of the “organic artist”: a figure whose activism is neither fully oppositional nor entirely assimilated, but who is situated in a shifting and contested space that continually redefines the forms and meanings of artistic engagement in contemporary Morocco.

1.1 - Methodology and positionality

Through a qualitative and interdisciplinary approach, this paper combines theoretical analysis with empirical fieldwork. In the first part, it offers a critical review of relevant literature to develop a working definition of activism that reflects its political, aesthetic, and social dimensions. Given its inherently hybrid nature, the study draws on insights from cultural studies, social theory, and political science, with a particular emphasis on social movements theory and critical perspectives on the public sphere.

Fieldwork was carried out over two months in Rabat and Casablanca (November-December 2023), which host dense networks of cultural initiatives and attract substantial state investment in the creative field, creating favorable conditions for accessing the activist scene. A total of twelve semi-structured interviews were conducted with a wide range of interlocutors, including activists, members of collectives, associations, NGOs, and professionals working within Morocco’s emerging⁴ cultural industry. While the initial intention was to focus exclusively on independent activists and collectives, this approach soon proved to be limited, and its scope was expanded to include associations and cultural industry professionals, envisioned not as separate entities but as part of the same ecosystem. Among the various actors encountered, two case studies were selected for this study: Guerrilla Cinema and the *Union des Étudiants pour le Changement du Système Éducatif* (UECSE), as they exemplify the long-term evolution of activism in Morocco, from direct protest engagement to more complex negotiations with institutions. Particular attention was paid to protecting interlocutors’ safety and privacy: names were withheld, and only roles or affiliations are reported.

Participant observation completed the interviews, taking place in a range of cultural settings with varying degrees of institutional involvement. Among them, the most relevant for this paper include the first *Forum Marocain des Industries Culturelles et Créatives*, the inauguration of *CollectifNar*’s first installation at Café La Scène, and several jam sessions organized by Fondation HIBA in Rabat, as well as the festival *L’Boulevard* and *KounAktif*’s exhibition “Fragility and Resilience at the Interstice of Our Architecture” in Casablanca.

⁴ The Moroccan cultural industry has been developing in recent years, as demonstrated by the first edition of the Moroccan Forum for Cultural and Creative Industries held in Rabat from 7 to 10 December 2023 (Fondation HIBA 2023).

Digital ethnography further enriched the empirical material. Social media platforms proved essential not only for initiating contact with interlocutors and gaining preliminary insights into their public profiles and artistic trajectories, but also for tracing the historical development of activist groups. The analysis covered public Facebook pages (Guerrilla Cinema, Hardzazate Hardcore Fest, UECSE – now *Tilila* – and *KounAktif*, along with related initiatives such *Festival de Résistance et d’Alternatives*, and *L’Boulevard Festival*); the YouTube channels of UECSE and *Tilila*; and the Instagram profiles of Hardzazate Hardcore Fest, *CollectifNar*, *KounAktif*, and their members. On Facebook and YouTube, the research relied primarily on digging back into earlier posts and uploads, as in 2011 these platforms served as key tools for organizing mobilization and disseminating protest messages among participants. By contrast, Instagram proved most useful for observing recent initiatives and analyzing how current activists publicize their work and position themselves within the contemporary public debate.

Throughout the investigation, my own positionality has played a critical role, both in gaining access to the field and in shaping the interpretation of the experiences encountered. As a white, middle class, European woman, I remained aware of the structural asymmetries and historical legacies that inform cross-cultural research. I sought to approach the field with openness and reflexivity, recognizing how my presence, background, and academic training inevitably influenced the research process. For that reason, I made a conscious effort to involve participants in the construction of the research itself: for instance, by asking whether they identified with the term “activist”, how they perceived it, and what meanings they associated with it. This was an attempt not to impose a predefined framework onto their practices, but rather to co-develop a situated understanding of the concept. At the same time, certain aspects of my identity contributed to creating an atmosphere of openness and trust, especially in conversations with younger interlocutors. Being in my late twenties helped foster more horizontal exchanges. Most of the individuals I engaged with were young, urban-based, and often embedded in culturally hybrid and internationally exposed environments. These affinities shaped not only the content of our conversations, but also the form: many interviews took place in English, a choice facilitated by generational familiarity with the language and, in some cases, a deliberate distancing from the symbolic weight of French and its association with colonial hierarchies. Language, however, remained a challenge. My limited command of *darija* sometimes made it difficult to fully grasp the nuances of cultural references and locally embedded expressions.

The following sections outline the research’s analytical and empirical path: first, the theoretical roots of activism and its ties to dissent, aesthetics, and the public sphere; then, Morocco’s sociopolitical context post-2011 protests; finally, how activist practices have evolved, reshaping their relationship with central power and institutions.

2 - Framing the activist: complexities of a definition

The term “artist” is believed to have originated within the Chicano movement in Los Angeles in the late 1960s (Funderburk 2021). “Believed” because it is difficult to pinpoint an exact moment when art began to be deliberately mobilized for socio-political purposes. Artists have long used their work to express convictions, expose contradictions and challenge power. What distinguishes activists is the socially and politically engaged content of their work, and the position they occupy within processes of social transformation, often participating in and coproducing change itself. As Duncombe and Lambert argue, the merging of art and activism forms a «powerful hybrid» (Funderburk 2021) that goes beyond simply raising awareness to actively promoting, enacting and embodying social change (Borrillo 2019). One of the most cited definitions of activism, offered by Asante (2008:206), says:

«The activist (artist+activist) uses her artistic talents to fight and struggle against injustice and oppression – by any medium necessary. The activist merges commitment to freedom and justice with the pen, the lens, the brush, the voice, the body, and the imagination. The activist knows that to make an observation is to have an obligation».

This definition captures the oppositional spirit of activists, framing them as figures firmly positioned against structures of oppression. Yet, it also risks flattening the multifaceted nature of their political agency to a rigid binary: oppressed vs oppressor; resistance vs cooptation; marginality vs power. In practice, however, the landscape is far more entangled: while activists are undeniably politically situated, they often engage with the very institutions they critique, as they offer primary means for visibility, recognition and economic survival. They operate as both agents of dissent and pragmatic actors.

As agents of dissent, activists disrupt hegemonic discourse and reconfigure the public sphere by voicing the demands of marginalized groups and intervening in arenas from which they are often excluded. This paper moves away from Jürgen Habermas’ (1992) normative model of the public sphere as a rational arena among equal citizens (Mouffe 2002:87-89; Butler 2015:79; Borrillo 2019:156), drawing instead on Nancy Fraser’s (1990:67) critique, which highlights structural inequalities and introduces the concept of «subaltern counterpublics»: alternative arenas where oppositional voices and collective identities can be articulated. These are not simply spaces of resistance but of redefinition, challenging dominant discourses and reframing what counts as public, political, and visible. Jacques Rancière (2004) further expands this view through the notion of dissensus, where politics and aesthetics intersect to reframe what is visible, audible, and thinkable. Activism, from this angle, is not merely a political expression, but

a political act that generates new «scenes of appearance» (13), challenging dominant distributions of voice and visibility.

«For me, making art would be meaningless without a political goal, especially in a context like this. (...) All my activities and my work, for better or worse, are linked to political or social issues».⁵

«I want to think of myself as an activist, someone who uses art as a tool for activism. Over the years (...) we have tried to create and achieve a space for freedom of expression. So, I like to think that my art is making room for freedom of expression».⁶

As pragmatic actors, activists must also navigate the material and economic dimensions of artistic engagement. They are not only political actors, they are also artists seeking recognition, financial stability, and visibility. Such necessity emerges both among activists and cultural entrepreneurs: «At some point, you have to work, you have to take responsibility, such as no longer living at your parent's house. You can't be a dreamer your whole life».⁷

«You cannot talk about change while overlooking economic and financial aspects. You can change the world by providing development capabilities, but also opportunities to generate income, because artists must also be able to pay taxes to their country, obtain visas to travel, and provide an education to their children. (...) We cannot overlook the financial aspect, as many people do».⁸

This creates practical dilemmas, as the very institutions capable of offering resources and legitimacy are often complicit in the structures of injustice they aim to critique or dismantle. In politically tense environments (LeVine 2015), activists frequently engage in tactical negotiations with the state to sustain their work and reach audiences (Abdelhak 2021). Their practices emerge in compromise with, rather than outside of, institutional frameworks. In the Moroccan case, this means confronting with the pervasive influence of the *Makhzen*,⁹ whose control over cultural production and public space

⁵ Interview with photographer and film-maker, online, December 19, 2023.

⁶ Interview with founder of *Théâtre de l'Opprimé*, online, December 6, 2023.

⁷ Interview with Guerrilla Cinema member, online, November 3, 2023.

⁸ Interview with a cultural actor from the civil society, Casablanca, November 11, 2023.

⁹ *Makhzen* refers to the traditional Moroccan state apparatus and patronage networks surrounding the monarchy.

deeply shapes the terms and possibilities of artistic activity. The figure of the “organic artist” captures the dual role of the activist as both a voice of dissent and an actor engaged with institutional realities. Adapted by Boubia (2019) from Gramsci’s (1971) notion of the organic intellectual, the organic artist is not defined by social class affiliation, but by alignment with an emergent worldview that, while still marginal, articulates aspirations for change increasingly shared across different segments of society. They give voice to politically and culturally sensitive perspectives – «such as secularism, democratic reform, and modernity» (Boubia 2014:565) – which confront dominant norms while resonating with latent collective desires for transformation (Boubia 2015). This conceptual lens places the organic artist, or activist, at the crossroads between dissent and institutional engagement.

«I would define activism (...) not necessarily as dissent or resistance, but simply using art as a means to advocate, to highlight issues and even to suggest alternatives. (...) It pushes to highlight different social political issues or even suggest better kinds of solutions, using different means: it would be through humor or sarcasm, through subtle means. I think that’s what makes activism particular in all other forms, that is subtle but also striking: it is not subtle in the sense that is not obvious, but it is subtle in the sense that it pushes you to think and reflect and eventually it engages large groups of people».¹⁰

Far from existing purely on the margins, activists must remain legible and operative within a constrained public sphere: «(...) you must ensure that people accept your art, that your work fits in with the location and does not create conflict with it or with the community that lives there».¹¹ To avoid marginalization or silencing, they are often compelled to interface, at least partially, with institutional frameworks (Abdelhak 2021). In a context like Morocco, where what happens in public space is often more important than laws, as it «shows what is actually tolerated by the majority and the authorities, even if it is against the law or traditions»,¹² activists operate in grey zones: between tolerated expression and covert dissent, between legitimacy and subversion. Activists thus act as «cultural intermediaries»,¹³ translating critique into forms that can circulate within existing constraints while subtly reconfiguring the boundaries of what is sayable, visible, and possible (Rancière 2004).

¹⁰ Interview with *KounAktif* co-founder, Casablanca, November 16, 2023.

¹¹ Interview with street artist, Rabat, November 13, 2023.

¹² Talk by Amina Boubia “From Festivals and Sports to Arts and Crafts: The Power of Popular Culture in Morocco”. Presented at the conference *Contested Plurality. Moroccan cultural and intellectual production as a new politics*, University of Munster, December 4, 2023.

¹³ Interview with Driss Ksikes, Rabat, December 15, 2023.

This hybrid positioning illustrates the micropolitical potential of contemporary activism (Serafini 2018): a slow, negotiated process of transformation that unfolds not through rupture, but through embedded, situated practices that rework power from within.

3 - Contextualizing the activist: trajectories of Moroccan activism before and after 2011

Although the term activism only gained prominence in the aftermath of the protests, the practices it denotes have much deeper roots. Even during the final decades of Hassan II's authoritarian reign, known as *Les Années de Plomb* ("Years of Lead"), artists carved out alternative channels for dissent and reimagined unexpected spaces for creative expression (Essafi 2021). The 2011 uprisings undoubtedly marked a turning point in visibility and public engagement, but they must be seen as part of a longer, more intricate trajectory of artistic resistance. Notably, the late 1990s and early 2000s witnessed a period of intense cultural vitality known as *Nayda*,¹⁴ in which post2011 activism should be contextualized.

«The artistic scene (...) started much more with music¹⁵ than films, there were a lot of bands playing rock and hip hop and stuff like these. Especially the rock people, they were getting crazy. The government started to arrest people, cut their hair into the street, telling them "you are satanist" to everybody who was following that look. This started creating questions to the minds of people and many people started organizing concerts of punk rock and it was how activism started. Then it came to theater and other arts (...)».¹⁶

Such cultural turmoil pioneered the use of artistic expression as a means of contestation, also prefiguring the ambivalent relationship between activists and the *Makhzen* that continue to define the field today. In fact, the state did not remain a passive spectator amid the growing spread of this energetic and subversive dissent. After initial attempts at repression proved largely ineffective (Mouna 2018), authorities opted for what Boum (2013:168) described as a «soft surveillance system», simultaneously promoting

¹⁴ In Moroccan Arabic, the term means "something is happening", "something is being born" and at the same time "cool", "everything is going well", "we are having fun".

¹⁵ At the core of the *Nayda* lies the *nouvelle scène*: an underground and subversive cultural current that embraced a range of musical genres and later served as a catalyst for other expressive forms.

¹⁶ Interview with Guerilla Cinema member, online, November 3, 2023.

and regulating cultural production. Through public funding for festivals¹⁷ – among the few stable income sources for artists – the state positioned itself as a central authority in the cultural field. It asserted the power to oversee artistic events from above, intervening in line-ups and establishing formalized pathways for artistic participation that mediate access to resources, visibility, and economic security. This dynamic, described as «festivalisation of dissent» (161),¹⁸ enabled the regime to co-opt cultural actors, contain critical voices and project an image of openness. The resulting system of «selective rewards» (Almeida 2017:43) fostered internal mistrust and accusations of complicity, fragmenting dissent and reinforcing the Moroccan image as a modern, democratic country, particularly in the eyes of external observers.¹⁹

«Even if you want to organize a festival independently, you still have to go through the state to request permission to occupy public space, and therefore limits may be placed on the messages you want to convey or the way you want to convey them. You cannot express your position through a tool provided by the state, and therefore the festival is not effective».²⁰

By the time the protests erupted in 2011, this system of controlled openness began to falter. Riding the wave of regional upheaval, a number of Moroccan activists, namely some rockers and rappers (Boubia 2019:98), increasingly refused the compromises that had previously enabled their participation in state-sponsored frameworks. Visibility or financial security at the cost of autonomy were no longer acceptable. In this context, the figure of the independent, resistant activist took shape: one committed to confronting power no matter the personal cost. This tendency is reflected in two chapters of the edited volume *Contemporary Morocco* (Maddy-Weitzman & Zisenwine

¹⁷ Piepzrak (2020) reports that in June-August 2006 alone, more than 15 art, music and film festivals took place in major urban centers and coastal cities. Funding for cultural centers and festivals increased even more after the 2003 Islamic terrorist attacks in Casablanca to counter radicalization in poor neighborhoods.

¹⁸ Boum (2013) employs the expression with reference to *L'Boulevard*, one of Morocco's largest music festivals. First held in Casablanca in 1999, it quickly became a hub for urban subcultures, playing a central role in the emergence of la nouvelle scène. While it continues to be associated with antiestablishment discourse, it has also become increasingly recognized by state institutions, receiving both symbolic and financial support. For a deeper analysis see LeVine (2008) and Almeida (2017).

¹⁹ Morocco is often framed and portrayed through the lens of “exceptionalism”. Yet scholars caution that, despite some advances (Cavatorta & Dalmasso 2013:120–121), significant constraints persist regarding freedom of expression and individual liberties. Rather than signaling democratic deepening, such reforms often serve strategies of co-optation and image management at both national and international levels.

²⁰ Interview with photographer and former activist from UECSE, Rabat, December 9, 2023.

2013), in which the authors depict Moroccan rappers as a homogeneous and oppositional category. Boum refers to them collectively as «new rebels» (174), while Ben-Layashi (2013:151) characterizes them as «revolutionaries and ‘anarchists’ hip-hop youngsters», overlooking the internal diversity and nuanced positions within the movement. This reading of artivism as inherently oppositional is understandable when situated within the exceptional political climate of the 2011 protests, during which many artists actively rejected any affiliation with institutional power. However, elevating this stance to a defining trait risks essentializing the figure of the activist through a partial, idealized, and ultimately romanticized lens: «In Morocco when you speak about subjects which are supposed to be normal, they can become engaged because you can’t talk about different stuff, so the context becomes engaged but it was not supposed to be in this way».²¹

As the momentum of the uprisings waned,²² so too did the sharp divisions between activists and institutional stakeholders. The dynamics of compromise, negotiation, and selective collaboration that had defined the pre-2011 landscape gradually resurfaced.

«At the beginning of the protests, all artists were activists. Then the cultural scene grew very quickly and the government got scared. They (street artists) tried to organize festivals, but the government exploited their poverty to create opportunities they couldn’t refuse. Sometimes you don’t have the chance to choose what kind of work to do».²³

This reconfiguration was closely tied to the outlines of the Moroccan protests themselves, which, unlike the revolutionary demands in Tunisia and Egypt, did not call for regime overthrow but rather for its democratization and greater accountability. While protestors in neighboring countries chanted for the fall of the government, the dominant slogan in Morocco was the fall of the *Makhzen*, leaving the monarchy’s symbolic authority largely unchallenged (Borrillo 2019:157). This distinction allowed King Mohammed VI to preserve the throne’s legitimacy while retaining control over the pace and shape of political change. In line with his longstanding strategy, the King responded with a carefully calibrated mix of concessions and manipulation. Just weeks after the mobilizations began, he inaugurated a process of constitutional reform (Benchemsi 2012) that culminated in the promulgation of the 2011 Constitution, later widely criticized for its lack of substantive reform and for the absence of democratic proce-

²¹ Interview with political rapper, online, December 12, 2023.

²² A new wave of mass mobilizations emerged in the Rif region in October 2016, demonstrating that discontent with the ruling authority persisted beyond 2011. However, these protests did not substantially alter the broader dynamics of negotiation and institutional co-optation within the cultural field discussed here.

²³ Interview with street artist, Rabat, November 13, 2023.

dures (Borrillo 2012; Bergh & Ahmadou 2018). At the same time, the monarchy sought to undermine the organized dissent led by the 20 February Movement (20FM): a grass-roots coalition that emerged spontaneously without centralized leadership, composed of highly diverse social and political forces united under the slogan “*karāma, hurriya, ‘adāla iġtimā’iyya*” (“dignity, freedom, social justice”). Through a combination of indirect discrediting²⁴ and overt repression (ElHachimi 2016), the state worked to weaken the movement’s credibility and curb its influence. As a result, the 20FM gradually lost momentum and popular support (Abdelhay & Belghazi 2015). In the process, prominent voices of dissent either renegotiated their roles within political and cultural institutions²⁵ or left the country altogether.

Faced with the reassertion of royal authority and the failure to achieve meaningful political transformation, many within the protest movement experienced a deep sense of disillusionment (Ahmadou & Bergh 2018). Yet this did not lead to political withdrawal. Rather, it spurred a shift in tactics. As traditional repertoires of contention – demonstrations, sit-ins, direct confrontation – proved increasingly ineffective against a system as adaptable and diffuse as the Moroccan state, activists began seeking alternative forms of expression (Ahmadou & Bergh 2018:96-98). As Bayat observes (2017:19), when social movements become more diffuse and flexible, so too does repression become more sophisticated and covert. Yet this dynamic is reciprocal: movements evolve in response, developing modes of action that operate within the limited spaces available to them. In the Moroccan context, this translated into a turn toward culture and artistic production as both a survival strategy and a site of resistance (Boubia 2015; Borrillo 2019).

«During the 2011 protests, it started big but at one point people started watching and listening to the protest more than protesting. Basically we felt we were doing a performance for the other people who were watching, so we started doing street performances about anything that is social, anything that is more like a protest we

²⁴ Among the more discreet strategies of repression is the regime’s promotion of pro-status quo popular movements, such as the *baltajia*. Their role in undermining the 20 February Movement is effectively captured in Nadir Bouchmouch’s documentary *My Makhzen and Me*, produced within the Guerrilla Cinema collective. See also Boubia 2019.

²⁵ A key example is Hoba Hoba Spirit, a rock-fusion group emblematic of the *Nayda* movement and Morocco’s underground scene. Closely monitored by authorities, especially after the 2003 Casablanca bombings, their politically charged lyrics once resonated with protest movements, most notably through their debut track, featured during the 2011 demonstrations. In recent years, however, frontman Reda has described the band as apolitical, distancing it from political discourse. Since then, they have regularly appeared at major state-sponsored festivals. See “Hoba Hoba Spirit – Mirikane”. Yabiladi. <https://bit.ly/43rB4by>. Last accessed 12/05/2025.

turned into a street performance». ²⁶

Artivists began to engage critically from within the very frameworks that constrained them, crafting practices of quiet contestation (Laine & Ltifi & Suurpää 2017) that challenged dominant narratives without overt defiance. Rather than choosing between collaboration and dissent, many navigated both simultaneously or alternately, adjusting their strategies in response to shifting political and material conditions. This strategic ambivalence – at once embedded and oppositional – helps explain why contemporary Moroccan artivism resists fixed categories: its contradictions reflect not incoherence, but an ongoing negotiation with power.

4 - Understanding the contemporary activist: two case studies

Looking at today's activist landscape in Morocco, what immediately stands out is its complexity, fragmentation, and often disjointed character. The scene brings together a wide array of individuals and collectives whose practices, goals, and networks vary significantly, frequently operating in isolation from one another. This heterogeneity reflects a series of transformations that have taken place since 2011, when the decline of the 20FM shifted artivism away from collective mobilization toward more individualized or association-based initiatives. Today, activists operate within a dense cultural ecosystem involving state bodies, international institutes, NGOs, and independent creatives. While this has expanded artistic opportunities, it has also blurred the lines between dissent, market dynamics, and institutional engagement. The fragmentation of the activist landscape and its shift away from direct confrontation have eased state control. Several interviewees noted that the field feels more accessible today:

«Now it's easier to create an association and anyone can do it so a lot messing around is going on. Before it was difficult, only the people who actually care were going through and there was a strong underground culture with strong values. Now anyone can do it: a lot people are in this field, either not skilled enough or money focused». ²⁷

Yet, this should not be mistaken for genuine liberalization. Censorship and surveillance persist, albeit in more discreet and fragmented forms, such as the removal of an unwelcome mural, the denial of public space for a performance or film shoot, bureaucratic obstacles to gaining association status, or the withholding of payments

²⁶ Interview with founder of *Théâtre de l'Opprimé*, online, December 6, 2023.

²⁷ Interview with a cultural actor from the civil society, Casablanca, November 11, 2023.

from dissident artists. What usually functions as a form of «soft surveillance» (Boum 2013:168) can thus harden into more direct forms of control when the regime perceives its stability to be at risk.²⁸ The result is a contradictory space in which, on the one hand, greater opportunities for artistic engagement have emerged, while on the other, the aspirations once tied to activism as a force for political transformation have been significantly blunted. «(...) the art and culture world are becoming depoliticized. There are still some collectives that still exist, but they are becoming less and less engaged politically and socially speaking».²⁹

Under these altered conditions, new actors, often younger and disconnected from 2011 protests, have entered the cultural scene. At the same time, state efforts to institutionalize cultural production, such as the first Forum for Cultural and Creative Industries (Fondation HIBA 2023), reveal how professionalization is becoming both a policy goal and a survival strategy. Despite its highly institutional character, the event also involved grassroots and local-scale artist. Concerns around co-optation appear to have been backgrounded when compared to more immediate issues like financial stability. As priorities shift, a set of unresolved questions emerges: how can artists maintain a critical voice within systems that demand compromise? Is dissent still possible from within institutional frameworks, and if so, under what conditions? What does activism mean in a landscape increasingly shaped by collaboration and appropriation?

Against this backdrop, the cases of Guerrilla Cinema and the *Union des étudiants pour le changement du système éducatif* (UECSE) helps unpack some of these complexities. Their trajectories reveal how groups once openly defiant have developed distinct, and at times contradictory, strategies to navigate a shifting political and cultural landscape. Each engages in an ongoing negotiation between informal resistance and formal collaboration. Their trajectories suggest that resistance has not disappeared, but it has simply taken on more complex and less conspicuous forms.

4.1 - From Guerrilla Cinema to Hardzazat Hardcore Fest

Guerrilla Cinema emerged in the wake of the 2011 protests in Morocco. Informal and fluid in structure, it revolved around a core group of young filmmakers and activists from the 20FM with diverse profiles, including students and former students of film schools, joined by volunteers and external collaborators. Their aspiration was to challenge the dominant cinema industry and document dissent from the bottom. Drawing inspiration from Latin American New Cinema and traditions of “engaged” or “Third Cinema”,³⁰ the collective embraced low-budget, independent filmmaking as

²⁸ See the case of *Racines* (Kadiri 2019).

²⁹ Interview with *KounAktif* co-founder, Casablanca, November 16, 2023.

³⁰ The term *Third Cinema* designates an aesthetic and political movement that emerged primar-

both artistic resistance and civil disobedience. Many founding members had ties to the Moroccan Association for Human Rights, which used politically engaged films to foster public debate. As street mobilizations intensified, they started documenting protests, often facing repression. Rejecting both censorship and official regulation, they bypassed the Moroccan Cinematographic Center (CCM) and its permit system, stating «We do not believe in censorship or in Moroccan cinematic law. Cameras are our weapons».³¹

As mobilizations waned in late 2011, they sought to sustain the spirit of dissent through monthly videos, until they decided: «Why not make a full-length film instead?».³² This led to their collaboration with Nadir Bouhmouch, a U.S. trained filmmaker and activist, who returned to Morocco to document the uprisings firsthand. Supported by the collective, Bouhmouch filmed the protests, interviewed activists and demonstrators, and integrated regional footage shared online. The result was *My Makhzen and Me*,³³ a documentary that garnered international attention. From this experience, Guerrilla Cinema was officially formed,³⁴ uniting around 30 young activists using independent cinema as an extension of their political engagement. Over the years, they produced several engaged documentaries (*The Mask*, *Srooted*, *475 le Film*, and *Basta!*) that tackled censorship and restrictions to cultural production, exposing the paradoxical nature of a state that promotes cinema while limiting who produces it. Beyond filmmaking, Guerrilla Cinema also participated in organizing the *Festival de Résistance et d'Alternatives*³⁵ at *Les Abattoirs* in Casablanca (2012-2014): a space for screenings, workshops, and debates that commemorated the spirit of the uprisings and promoted alternative forms of citizenship. Its closure reflected the declining visibility of the 20FM: «Since the movement no longer made strong statements or was present in the streets, continuing the festival felt less urgent, though it still made sense as a way to remember».³⁶

Many members moved to Ouarzazate, Morocco's film industry hub, where they continued their creative work while gradually distancing themselves from their activist past. In 2015, they launched the Hardzazat Hardcore Fest³⁷ : a music festival politically charged yet less directly tied to the 20FM label, which had become increasingly dan-

ily in Latin America and Africa, as an alternative to both Hollywood (*First Cinema*) and European films (*Second Cinema*). It sought to function as a tool for social and political transformation, aligning itself with anticolonial and revolutionary struggles. See Solanas & Getino 1970.

³¹ "Guerrilla Cinema". Radical Film Network. <https://bit.ly/3Zh8x62>. Last accessed 12/05/2025.

³² Interview with Guerrilla Cinema member, online, November 3, 2023.

³³ "My Makhzen and Me". YouTube. <https://bit.ly/3UFUSnK>. Last accessed 12/05/2025.

³⁴ "Guerrilla Cinema". Facebook. <https://bit.ly/3M8YagZ>. Last accessed 25/11/2025.

³⁵ "Festival de résistances et d'alternatives". Festival de résistances et d'alternatives. <https://bit.ly/49zHshT>. Last accessed 12/05/2025.

³⁶ Interview with Guerrilla Cinema member, online, November 3, 2023.

³⁷ "Festival concept". Hardzazat Hardcore Fest. <https://bit.ly/43q61Ng>. Last accessed 25/11/2025.

gerous to claim publicly. This transition is better understood by Youness Belghazi, one of the Guerrilla Cinema founders and former 20FM activist, who described the collective work as a form of activism since 2011. He believed that artistic practices, whether through independent cinema or music, remained a catalyst for social change, even as street protests faded (Shirk 2016). This foundational belief helps explain the group's evolution: fourteen years after the uprisings, many former activists no longer follow a political agenda. Instead of abandoning their commitment altogether, they have shifted toward a more grounded, relational form of engagement: as one member put it «When you no longer have an agenda, what you must do is be there for people».³⁸

Even in the absence of an organized political agenda or sustained political pressure, the role of the activist becomes one of listening and responding to the social needs of the people. Aware that many have grown accustomed to state-sponsored festivals and mainstream cultural consumption, activists have reappropriated this very format turning it into a site of transformation by rejecting institutional partnerships and resisting market-driven or liberal cultural models. Hardzazat Hardcore Fest has positioned itself precisely as such a space: a free and independent forum for creative expression, untouched by state control, commercial logic, or cultural hegemony. Even its most recent edition, held in May 2023, refused any sponsorship or official endorsement. Entry remained open and free, conditional only on adherence to its antidiscriminatory values. Framed as an antifa and decolonial festival,³⁹ Hardzazat includes feminist and queer sections and promotes Amazigh cultural revival. Its rhetoric, both in tone and content, retains the spirit of Guerrilla Cinema's resistance. As organizers wrote on Facebook:

«In the 'new and exceptional' Morocco, Hardzazat still scares the authorities and the police... In our fantasies, we dream of a democratic country where we can share culture freely. In reality, people are jailed for the most basic reasons. The Makhzen suppresses any dissent, using violence, censorship, and propaganda».⁴⁰

Tracing the trajectory of several former members of Guerrilla Cinema who redirected their political and cultural engagement into the Hardzazat Hardcore Fest illustrates the adaptability of activism in shifting political landscapes. While the festival now exists within a broader institutional terrain, it continues to operate as an independent platform for dissident expression. This transition shows that creativity and resistance remain viable tools for social transformation, even within increasingly institutionalized

³⁸ Interview with Guerrilla Cinema member, online, November 3, 2023.

³⁹ "Festival concept". Hardzazat Hardcore Fest. <https://bit.ly/43q61Ng>. Last accessed 25/11/2025.

⁴⁰ "Hardzazat Hardcore Fest". Facebook. <https://bit.ly/4ohwR1s>. Last accessed 25/11/2025.

environments. In this sense, artistic practice retains its political meaning even when detached from explicit protest. The activist does not disappear with the movement: they transform, adapt, and continue to generate spaces where alternative imaginaries can persist.

4.2 - The fragmentation of UECSE: *CollectifNar*, and *KounAktif*

The *Union des étudiants pour le changement du système éducatif* (Union of students for change in the education system, UECSE) was established in 2012, when a group of Moroccan students meeting informally in the Cervantes Park in Rabat decided to advocate for structural educational reform through mobilization and inclusive national debate. It quickly became a platform fostering critical thinking, dialogue, and civic engagement among youth through initiatives that blended political engagement, cultural expression, and artistic intervention, such as *Falsafa fi zanka* (“Philosophy in the streets”), *Haz al-kitab w-haji tkraa* (“Grab a book and come read”), and *L’Université Populaire au Maroc*⁴¹ (“Popular University in Morocco”) (Borrillo 2019:158-159). On August 6th 2012 the UECSE called for a national demonstration that led it to expand into eight regional sections, particularly in Casablanca, where “Philosophy in the Streets” became a weekly public event, and was even exported abroad, inspiring similar initiatives in Tunis.

As the collective matured, activism became an increasingly central component of its strategy, offering a way to foster public participation, to reclaim space, and to resist dominant narratives. However, this expansion also brought internal tensions around the prospects of seeking official recognition as an association: an essential status for securing venues, applying to public grants, and accessing funding. Some members advocated for a broader agenda that included individual rights and minority issues, while others feared this would jeopardize their legal recognition. These disagreements culminated in a split in 2015: the UECSE dissolved, and *Tilila*⁴² was founded to carry forward its legacy within a more formal structure. Since obtaining legal status in 2017, *Tilila* has become a key reference point for youth activism in Rabat. Yet, it represents only one outcome of the UECSE’s trajectory. Other initiatives, such as *CollectifNar* and *KounAktif*, have embraced activism as their primary mode of engagement, operating in a dynamic space between informal initiatives and formal recognition.

Co-founded in 2021 by an artist, activist, and researcher who was involved in the UECSE but took distance from the group due to its male-dominated dynamics,⁴³ *Collec-*

⁴¹ “L’Université Populaire au Maroc”. Facebook. <https://bit.ly/3w1Yell>. Last accessed 25/11/2025.

⁴² “Tilila Rabat”. Facebook. <https://bit.ly/44lzc4e>. Last accessed 25/11/2025.

⁴³ Interview with *CollectifNar* co-founder, online, December 29, 2023. The same opinion about power dynamics and masculine presence in UECSE was shared by another interview with an

*tifNar*⁴⁴ operates at the intersection of feminist activism, art, and pedagogy. The project focuses on empowerment through emotional and sexual health education, participatory events, and artistic installations. Their first public exhibition, centered on the theme of consent, was hosted at *Café La Scène*: a cultural venue managed by the *Fondation HIBA*,⁴⁵ supported by King Mohammed VI itself. This collaboration exemplifies the delicate balancing that defines *CollectifNar*'s practice: while grounded in decolonial and radical feminist approaches, the collective constantly negotiates the boundaries of what can be said or shown within official infrastructures. Their strategy is not one of open confrontation but of quiet persistence, working from within institutional spaces while maintaining a critical distance and awareness of their limits.

«We are really careful with what we do. Honestly, super careful. We are like very quietly working and paying attention to what we say in order not to be in the radar. (...) You can say almost everything, it's not much about sexuality we couldn't talk, it's more about other things. And if you talk about other things, they might annoy you for talking about sexuality».⁴⁶

This ambivalence can be understood considering the long-term aim of the project: to engage in a public dialogue through cultural and pedagogical activities in order to achieve gradual, lasting social transformation. From this temporal perspective, the initial mistrust of seeing such an initiative within a site under governmental auspices is dispelled: collaborating *hic et nunc* with state institutions does not necessarily mean giving up a transformative perspective regarding the future.

A parallel path was taken by *KounAktif*,⁴⁷ founded in 2018 in Casablanca by two former UECSE activists, artists and philosophy students previously involved in "Philosophy in the Streets". As the UECSE dissolved and passed the torch to *Tilila*, the founders of *KounAktif* sought to reinvent their activism through a more experimental and intersectional lens. Conceived as a creative laboratory, the collective brings together art, critical theory, and community-based practices to foster new forms of civic engagement. Its very name – "Be Active" – is a call to action, encouraging people to stop waiting for change and instead become proactively involved in it. Established as a collective, *KounAktif* initially operated through collaborations and borrowing spaces from other

activist and former activist from UECSE, Rabat, December 18, 2023.

⁴⁴ "CollectifNar". Instagram. <https://bit.ly/4ofpCqI>. Last accessed 25/11/2025.

⁴⁵ "La fondation". Fondation Hiba. <https://bit.ly/4kaZJHD>. Last accessed 25/11/2025.

⁴⁶ Interview with *CollectifNar* co-founder, online, December 29, 2023.

⁴⁷ "Kounaktif". Linktree. <https://bit.ly/3RXYRcP>. Last accessed 25/11/2025.

associations.⁴⁸ In 2021, it gained official association status and secured its own space in Casablanca: *L'Fadae*. More than a workspace, *L'Fadae* serves as an artist residency and cultural hub where visual art, music, philosophy, science, and Do-It-Yourself practices converge. The space is envisioned as a support structure for creative experimentation, aiming to democratize cultural access and provide a platform for marginalized voices, whether shaped by class, gender, geography, or economic precarity. Intersectionality is the guiding paradigm of *KounAktif*'s work. Art is conceived as a «tool of resistance against imposed realities, and subtle means of expression that foster social innovation and community resilience».⁴⁹ This strong focus on marginality and inequality may seem at odds with *KounAktif*'s collaborations with international organizations and EU-funded projects, which often adhere to more liberal, depoliticized understandings of art. However, maintaining coherence between their political vision and external collaborations relies on careful project selection: «We can't collaborate with anyone if there are limits. The prerequisite is converging principles, interests and goals. If these are met, everything else comes smooth».⁵⁰ This selective approach allows *KounAktif* to navigate structural asymmetries while preserving a degree of autonomy and coherence between their values and practices. Rather than perceiving this tension as a constraint, the collective approaches it consciously and with a touch of irony, treating negotiation as an integral part of their activist methodology. As one co-founder explained: «We don't care about the limits imposed by these entities, because we know how to zigzag between what we want to do and what we are allowed to do».⁵¹

Taken together, *CollectifNar* and *KounAktif* exemplify the adaptive potential of post-UECSE artivism. By reconfiguring activist strategies to include pedagogy, therapy, intersectional feminism, and experimental art, they demonstrate how resistance can endure, if not always in the streets, then in cultural spaces that resist normalization and remain committed to social transformation.

5 - Conclusions

When artivism gained prominence as a transformative force alongside conventional repertoires of contention during the 2011 protests, the line of opposition were clearly drawn: on one side stood the protesters, the 20 February Movement, and the mass mobilizations that spread across the country; on the other side stood the monarchy and the *Makhzen*, the oppressive and unequal political system grounded in censorship and repressive power structures. As the initial momentum of the protests faded, however,

⁴⁸ Interview with *KounAktif* co-founder, Casablanca, November 16, 2023.

⁴⁹ Ibid.

⁵⁰ Ibid.

⁵¹ Ibid.

the binary opposition between government and civil society began to blur, and the logics of dialogue and compromise that had long shaped the Moroccan cultural scene reemerged. As evidenced by the case studies, activists who first positioned themselves in stark opposition to the establishment, gradually compromised to coexist with it. Guerrilla Cinema evolved into an independent festival, becoming one of the few initiatives that has maintained a genuine distance from institutional partnerships and state funding. The UECSE gave rise to a series of transformative initiatives which, in different ways, have received institutional recognition but simultaneously contribute to enriching the country's socio-cultural landscape by investing in education and long-term change.

This diversity reflects a broader fragmentation of the activist field. Interviews reveal that both individual artists and collectives are developing a range of strategies to navigate this shifting landscape. On a personal level, some activists separate their artistic and activist roles, engaging in commercial or mainstream work to gain visibility and financial stability, while compartmentalizing their socio-political engagement. At the same time, collectives and associations adopt similar strategies: they selectively join projects and institutional partnerships that do not compromise their core values, or they implement programs focused on smaller audiences, such as individual or small scale communities. These initiatives often adopt pedagogical approaches aimed at long-term transformation. In this way, their work is less likely to provoke hostility from the monarchy: the emphasis shifts from the social to the personal, with the hope that social transformation may eventually emerge from the personal back to the social. These observations lead to three central insights.

First, the transformative spirit of the 2011 uprisings did not vanish with the dissolution of the 20 February Movement or the subsequent political stabilization. Instead, it persisted through alternative, non-conventional repertoires of contention. According to Tarrow (1998), all collective mobilizations follow a trajectory that ultimately leads to their decline, whether due to internal fragmentation, failure to resist co-optation, repression, or even success. Yet the end of a social movement's organizational form does not necessarily mean the end of its participants' commitment to change. Activism may no longer constitute a formally organized protest movement, but it still plays a significant role in socio-political transformation. This invites a different reading of movement decline: not as disappearance, but as strategic adaptation through new repertoires of contestation. From this perspective, episodes of rupture and revolution are merely the visible peaks of a broader process of resistance, one that also relies on quieter, subtler tools, such as art and creativity. The current configuration of Moroccan activism can thus be seen as a phase of «silent contention» (Boubia 2019:95), in which dissent persists below the surface, adapting to the constraints of the sociopolitical context. Yet, this silence is neither synonymous with resignation nor with disengagement. Rather, it

contains the potential to become «voiced contention» (95) again, should the conditions for renewed mobilization arise.

Second, activists in Morocco are faced with a dilemma: either remain outsiders, detached from institutional ties, preserving a pure countercultural identity, or become, at least partially, mainstream by drawing on institutional resources and producing content more aligned with dominant cultural norms. They have chosen the latter. What defines the contemporary activist is precisely this ambiguity, this intrinsic contradiction. Driven by a desire for legitimacy, stability and visibility, they have opted not for direct opposition, but for a strategic entanglement with power, engaging it on various levels. In doing so, they have taken on the role of the “organic artist”, abandoning total independence and occupying intermediate positions between the revolutionary artist and the state.

Finally, the figure of the contemporary activist as an “organic artist” must be understood as someone capable of inhabiting multiple spaces and performing multiple roles within the cultural and political scene, traversing different levels of institutionalization: from independent artist, to member of an association, to cultural entrepreneur. In doing so, they become familiar not only with the boundaries of what is legally permitted, but also with the gray areas where transgression is still possible. This holds subversive significance, especially in a country like Morocco, where what happens in the public space often outweighs the written law, showing what is tacitly tolerated, even if technically forbidden. The activist operates precisely in these interstices, between the tolerated and the prohibited, between the margins and the mainstream, embodying both resistance to the system and complicity with it.

Contemporary activism, therefore, no longer fits the expectations of the uprising moment: resistance, idealized struggles against injustice, and open opposition to central power. As the pressure for radical change has waned, the activist has been reintegrated into the realm of the banal: the ordinary and inescapable web of relationships where creative action unfolds in everyday life. This form of action may no longer aim to overturn dominant norms, but at times conforms to them for pragmatic reasons. Yet adaptation has not stripped activism of its transformative potential. Instead, it has prompted artists to carve out new spaces for resistance: gradual, small-scale, long-term efforts oriented toward change.

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